

V Therapeutic options

5.1 Summary of therapeutic recommendations

Recommendations are based on available evidence and expert consensus. Available evidence and expert voting lead to classification of strength of recommendation.

VI Treatment of comedonal acne

VI.1 Recommendations for comedonal acne*

Strength of recommendation	Recommendation
----- -----	High strength of recommendation
None	Medium strength of recommendation
Topical retinoids† can be recommended for the treatment of comedonal acne	
Low strength of recommendation	Benzoyl peroxide (BPO) can be considered for the treatment of comedonal acne
Azelaic acid can be considered for the treatment of comedonal acne	
Negative recommendation	Topical antibiotics are not recommended for the treatment of comedonal acne
Hormonal antiandrogens, systemic antibiotics, and/or systemic isotretinoin are not recommended for the treatment of comedonal acne	
Artificial ultraviolet (UV) radiation is not recommended for the treatment of comedonal acne	
Open recommendation	A recommendation for or against treatment of comedonal acne with visible light as monotherapy, lasers with visible or infrared wavelengths, intense pulsed light (IPL), or photodynamic therapy (PDT) cannot be made at the present time

Limitations can apply that may necessitate the use of a treatment with a lower strength of recommendation as first-line therapy (e.g., financial resources/reimbursement limitations, legal restrictions, availability, drug licensing).

†Adapalene (see chapter 9.1).

VI.2 Reasoning

General comment: Only one trial specifically evaluates patients with comedonal acne. Due to the lack of direct evidence, trials involving patients with papulopustular acne were used as indirect evidence, with the percentage reduction in non-inflammatory lesions considered the primary outcome. Because of the overall paucity of direct data, the strength of recommendation was downgraded for all treatment options, with a maximum starting point of medium strength.

Choice of topical vs. systemic treatment

Given the typically mild-to-moderate severity of comedonal acne, topical therapy is generally preferred.

Table 2 Summary of therapeutic recommendations†*

	Comedonal acne	Mild-to-moderate papulopustular acne	Severe papulopustular/moderate nodular acne	Severe nodular/conglobate acne§
High strength of recommendation	–	Adapalene + BPO (f.c.) or BPO + clindamycin (f.c.)	–	–